last updated
May 22, 2025

Designed by
Digital Team

Indigenous Digital Editorial Guide

Bow Valley College is an inclusive community that respects Indigenous ways of doing, being and learning. It is always appropriate to seek clarification from an Indigenous person, group, or representative who holds the relevant knowledge or responsibility for correct pronunciation, references, terms, and introductions. This is the first step toward understanding and respect. There are three distinct groups of Indigenous Peoples recognized by the Canadian Government: First Nations (status and non-status Indigenous peoples), Inuit, and Métis.

Bow Valley College uses language that communities of Indigenous Peoples use to describe themselves and as such, has moved from using the term "Aboriginal" to "Indigenous". Each group of peoples has their own unique histories, traditions, cultures and ways with diversity within each group.

The term "Indian" is a legal term used within current legislature (e.g. Indian Act). Note: Indigenous Peoples includes First Nations, Métis and Inuit. The speaker cannot interchange "First Nations" when referring to all Indigenous Nations. First Nation or Nations is widely accepted and has accepted.

First Nation(s) is widely used by status and non-status Indians (as described in the Indian Act). It does not include Métis and Inuit people.

Acknowledging the physical location when gathering a group of individuals, it is appropriate to communicate the speakers' and institution's connection to the land and the responsibility to the original Peoples.

Why do we acknowledge the land?

Land acknowledgments offered in post-secondary institutions originated as a practice that disrupted the erasure of Indigenous Peoples from the land and the Canadian narrative. Today, land acknowledgments have become more common, and have evolved to be a sign of respect for the land and its original Peoples. Offering a land acknowledgement is also an opportunity to express our responsibilities to the land, and to identify the kind of relationships we are striving to build. Acknowledging the land is a practice that everyone can engage in, and it can be a prompt for further action towards reconciliation. It is appropriate for this land acknowledgment to be used consistently in all printed material, especially materials that are used outside of our college community (in student recruitment, for example).

For smaller spaces, such as: email signatures, business cards, website footers

Bow Valley College is situated in Treaty 7 territory. We honour the territories and Peoples of the Blackfoot Confederacy: which includes the Siksika, Kainai, Piikani, and Amskapi Piikani (Blackfeet) First Nations; the Tsuut'ina First Nation; and the Îyâxe Nakoda: which includes the Goodstoney, Chiniki, and Bearspaw First Nations. We also acknowledge the historical Northwest Métis homeland and the Otipemisiwak Métis Government of Alberta, districts 4, 5, and 6 in Battle River territory.

some pronunciations:

- *"Amskapi Piikani" [Um-ska-pi Be-gaan-ii]*
- *"Otipemisiwak" [Oh-teh-pim-swak]*

Full Bow Valley College Land Acknowledgement

Bow Valley College aims to uphold the intention of the numbered friendship treaties from the perspective of Indigenous Peoples. As an Education institution in Treaty 7 territory, it is our responsibility to support a deeper understanding of this Treaty so that we can respect and honour its terms and respect Indigenous Peoples' legal and inherent rights. As a college, we know we have more to learn and that there is more we can do to deepen our capacity to work alongside Indigenous communities in reciprocal ways.

We acknowledge the Blackfoot Confederacy: which includes the Siksika, Kainai, Piikani, and Amskapi Piikani First Nations; we acknowledge the Tsuut'ina First Nation; we acknowledge the Îyâxe Nakoda First Nations: which include the Goodstoney, Chiniki, and Bearspaw.

We also acknowledge the historical Northwest Métis homeland and the Otipemisiwak Métis Government of Alberta, districts 4, 5, and 6 in Battle River territory.

We acknowledge and express our gratitude to the Indigenous caretakers of this land. We join all Nations in celebrating the unique histories, traditions, and contributions of Indigenous Peoples as we continue our journey of reconciliation together.

Why is terminology important?

Using the correct terminology is not just a matter of politeness, but it is crucial for respect and accuracy. Indigenous Peoples often prefer to be referred to by the traditional name of their specific community rather than general terms. This approach acknowledges and respects the diversity and unique heritage of each community.

By using respectful and accurate terminology, we can work towards a more inclusive and respectful dialogue between Canadian institutions and Indigenous communities.

When in doubt as to what is the most appropriate term to use, ask the person or group involved, learn what is in use in your area or subject field or simply ask someone knowledgeable.

capitalization

Use uppercase for the terms “Indigenous,” “First Nations”, “Inuit”, and “Métis” in all cases, consistent with the larger global community of specific demographics, e.g., Europeans, American. As a general adjective in non-specific running text, “native” and/or “indigenous” is not capitalized. *For example, “milkweed is indigenous to the region” or “he’s a native Calgarian.”*

Capitalize traditional Indigenous titles when preceding a name (for example, Chief, Hereditary Chief, Grand Chief, and Elder”.

The term "Peoples" emphasizes the collective nature of Indigenous rights, including the right to self-determination. This is crucial because self-determination is a collective right that allows Indigenous peoples to decide their own political status, economic, social, and cultural development. This recognition is essential for respecting and protecting unique identities and ways of life.

Indigenous negotiators advocated strongly for the United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples the use of the term "Peoples" instead of "People" because it recognizes the collective rights and distinct identities of various Indigenous groups.

Note that some Indigenous Nations and organizations do not capitalize their names.
Example: shíshálh Nation, amiskwaciy Academy

Not Inclusive	**Inclusive Language Alternatives**
Indian, Native, Aboriginals (not favourable terms however some Indigenous people may refer to themselves in this way)	Indigenous; Indigenous Peoples; First Nations, Métis, Inuit; students of Indigenous ancestry; self-identified Indigenous students and staff
Indigenous, elder (not capitalized words)	Indigenous, Elder (capitalized), Knowledge Keeper, ceremonialist
Indigenous worldview	Shared worldviews of some (or many) Indigenous Peoples' worldviews (plural)
The Indigenous community	Indigenous communities; try not to use "nations" as it derives from original term "First Nations" which is no longer acceptable.
Referring to First Nations people as a homogeneous group	Include someone's specific Nation, community, or band (use the spelling the band prefers, including accents and macrons)
Aboriginal, Native, and Indian	Indigenous Peoples - always capitalize
Reserve, the rez	Territory, community, ancestry, home
Primitive culture	Early cultures

Some things to avoid:

- Avoid using “nation” to refer to a whole cultural group. For example, instead of saying "Sarah Johnson is from the Blackfoot Nation," it is more acceptable and respectful to say: "Sarah Johnson is Blackfoot."
- Avoid using “Indigenous” in a generic way. Indigenous Peoples encompass a broad diversity of histories, cultures, language groups and identities as well as diverse interests and grievances. The erasure of these differences and rich diversity — often substituted with vague or imagined narratives — remains a challenge.
- Avoid using possessive phrases like "Canada's Indigenous Peoples" or "our Indigenous Peoples" as they imply ownership
- Be specific about a person’s Indigenous community, nation, territory and/or family connections if it’s how they want to be identified, rather than using a general descriptor.

Avoid outdated terms unless they’re formalized in organizational, geographical names, or legislation.

- Aboriginal groups
- Aboriginal interest
- Band (Unless referring to a local Nation that uses this term, check with the Nation first for proper reference)
- Eskimo: Do not use ‘Eskimo’ which the Inuit consider to be a derogatory term.
- Indian (Unless referring to a local Nation that uses this term, such as ‘Adams Lake Indian Band’. Or it is part of legislation like the ‘Indian Act’ or ‘Status Indian’)
- Native (Unless it is part of an organization name such as ‘Native Women’s Association of Canada’)
- Traditional (i.e. traditional knowledge, traditional territories, makes it seem like it is only applicable to the past and not the present.) When referring to ceremonies, please check with the local Nation’s website for assistance on whether to include ‘traditional’.
- Tribe (Unless referring to a local Nation that uses this term, such as ‘Cowichan Tribes’. ‘Tribe’ may also be appropriate when working with groups or individuals in the U.S.A.)

All First Nations, Métis and Inuit peoples are Indigenous . However, not all Indigenous Peoples identify with a First Nations community. Indigenous Peoples is the preferred term .

- Do not use the abbreviation FNMI
- Consultation vs . engagement: Consultation is used for the government’s legal duty to discuss. Engagement refers to meaningful discussion on areas of mutual concern.
- Avoid the congratulatory: Don’t offer meaningless platitudes or congratulate Indigenous Peoples for obvious things (Indigenous Peoples are important to Alberta’s economy)
- Treat issues, such as missing and murdered Indigenous women, with directness and respect
- Use First Nation rather than band
- The accent in Métis should be present in all cases, except when referring to the Métis Settlements or Métis Settlements General Council, because the legislation does not contain the accent
- Use people instead of persons wherever possible, but Indigenous Peoples (plural)

Indigenous pictures, videos, and art:

- Indigenous artworks often include important cultural symbols and stories. To respect these works, it's crucial to provide proper attribution to avoid trivialization and appropriation. When using videos, photos, or graphics of Indigenous artworks, always attribute them to the artist, including their Indigenous affiliation, the artwork's name, and its location.
  - attribute all images including video, photographic or graphics to the artist
  - include a title when available
  - secure permission to use the artwork and be explicit about uses for the artwork (unless in the public domain); be prepared to compensate for additional use
  - ensure the images appropriately reflect the distinct Indigenous groups (First Nations, Métis, and Inuit) when selecting imagery
  - Ensure you understand the ethics and operations of a business if you are buying artwork; preferable to buy directly from the artist

- Be aware that some artwork by non-Indigenous artists is created to look like Indigenous art or inspired by Indigenous art styles and may not be appropriate for us. Use caution when sourcing imagery from stock sites or online.

- When selecting images, it's important to ensure they are directly tied to the event, day of significance, or community being represented. For example, avoid using an image from the Sisters-in-Spirit Walk to illustrate an Orange Shirt Day story, or an image representing Blackfoot culture for a story about the Métis Nation. Additionally, exercise caution with AI-generated images, as they often present a pan-Indigenous perspective and may not accurately reflect the distinct identities, traditions, or symbolism of specific Nations or communities. Always strive for accuracy and cultural respect in visual representation.

Editing or publishing Indigenous knowledge

You must get approval from the original Indigenous source of information before publishing content that includes any aspect of Indigenous knowledge, especially Oral Tradition. You must acknowledge who taught you and the permission that you have been given to share. This may involve:

- Relationship building with Knowledge Keepers
- Creating a data sharing partnership
- Discussion with the branch that stores data
- Gaining consent from the knowledge source as to how they're credited and how the information is used

Fonts for Indigenous languages

First Nations Unicode Font allows you to render certain characters used in First Nation languages in your preferred font.



last updated
November 22, 2024

Designed by
Digital/Web/Social Team

Editorial Guide

Consistency is everything.

The more consistent we are, the more likely it is that people will understand our value. A consistent voice across all communication breeds trust – a crucial component.

Aboriginal	Before ‘Indigenous’ became the preferred term, ‘Aboriginal’ was used in Canada to describe First Nations, Métis, and Inuit in Canada. This term is still used in some legal documents in Canada, but many Indigenous Peoples dislike this term because *‘ab’* means ‘*not’* or ‘*away from’*. Whereas Indigenous means ‘*sprung from the land’*. Use “Aboriginal” as an adjective, not a noun. Avoid phrases like “the Aboriginals of Canada” or “June is an Aboriginal,” as they are reductive and evoke colonial-era terminology. Be aware that Aboriginal people do not "belong" to Canada. Avoid using possessive terms like "Canada's Aboriginal people" or "our Aboriginal people," as these are insulting and evoke a history of paternalism and control.
artifact	avoid. Use “cultural materials.” Artifact implies the object exists in the past and negates its current meaning in living cultures.
band	capitalize when it is part of a specific band, otherwise use lowercase.
Calgarians/ Albertans	The term 'Calgarians' or ‘Albertans’ is often used to reference people living in Calgary or Alberta. This term excludes Indigenous Peoples who may not identify with it. For many, they identify as members of their own sovereign nations and do not consider themselves part of one that has actively worked to assimilate their people. These terms can also exclude other groups such as newcomers and refugees. We recommend instead saying 'people living in Calgary/Alberta'.
Calls to Action	capitalize in order to distinguish from the generic term call to action. *For example, the Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Canada released 94 Calls to Action in its 2015 report on the Indian Residential School System.*
Creation/ the Creator	capitalize
discover, discovery	do not use to describe the arrival of Europeans or in reference to gravesites at residential schools. (See unmarked graves below) Indigenous Peoples were not discovered and Indigenous communities have long known about the unmarked graves at Indian Residential Schools.

elder/Elder	capitalize when used as an honorific directly preceding a name. Lowercase as a descriptor, similar to professor, dean, prime minister or reverend. *Exception:* capitalize Elder as a standalone word in documents for Indigenous communities, similar to The Canadian Press editorial style for the Pope. An elder/Elder is “a man or woman whose wisdom about spirituality, culture and/or life is recognized by the community. Elders can be any age although they generally have many years of experience.”
First Nations	using lowercase is generally not accepted as capitalization is a sign of respect and acknowledgement. First Nations are the Indigenous Peoples of Canada who are neither Métis nor Inuit. It can be plural or singular, *for example, Piikani First Nation.* While First Nation is commonly used in Treaty 7, elsewhere in Canada it may not be the preferred term and “Indigenous Peoples” may be used instead. Always keep in mind that including a First Nation’s full name is more accurate as well as more respectful of actual identity. *For instance, instead of saying “Linda, an Indigenous student, is a first-year science student,” it is preferable to say “Linda, a Katzie First Nation member, is a first-year science student.”* This approach shows respect and acknowledges the unique identity of each community.
FNMI	spell out First Nations, Métis and Inuit. Some groups and individuals prefer this term rather than “Indigenous” – use their preference.
Hereditary Chief	Hereditary Chiefs inherit their title. Their responsibilities and governing principles are according to the history and cultural values of their community. Hereditary Chiefs are the caretakers of the people and the culture. In addition to governance responsibilities, they may carry or share the responsibility of ensuring the traditions, protocols, songs, and dances of the community are respected and kept alive.
Indian/Indian Act	The term "Indian" is largely archaic and carries negative connotations for many Indigenous people in Canada. It should be avoided in most contexts, except when used in historical references, legacy terms, or specific government policies and classifications, such as the Indian Act, "status Indian," or "Musqueam Indian Band". In legal and policy contexts, terms like "status Indian," "Indian status," or simply "status" refer to the government's classification system under the Indian Act. This system confers certain benefits and has historically imposed penalties. Given the sensitivities involved, it is advisable to consult with knowledgeable individuals before using these terms. use only if it’s preferred by an individual or community or it’s part of a proper noun (e.g., the Indian Act). It’s sometimes used by older Indigenous folks who grew up with the term.

Indian Residential School System	use full name in first reference. (See more under the Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Canada)
indigenization	lowercase; to incorporate Indigenous worldviews, knowledge and perspectives into non-Indigenous educational, political and social structures
Indigenous	In a Canadian context, the term "Indigenous" is used to refer collectively to the First Nations, Métis, and Inuit who are "Indigenous" to what is now called Canada. There are Peoples who are "Indigenous" to their own local territories across the globe. Since "Indigenous" is a general term, it is often better to be more specific when referring to Indigenous Nations. *For example, in Treaty 7, we may be speaking about the 'Siksika First Nation' or about 'Blackfoot perspectives'.* Remember that Indigenous nations existed before national, provincial and other colonial boundaries were imposed. When writing about Indigenous topics, lands or Peoples, consider using "in what is now Canada/Alberta/Edmonton," etc. 'Indigenous' is usually capitalized; use lowercase when used as a general adjective to describe something that is originating from a particular region but not referring to Indigenous Peoples. *For example, 'Milkweed is indigenous to the region.'*
Indigenous Ways of Knowing, Being, and Doing	Indigenous understandings, practices and modes of learning from the people, animals and plant nations and the holistic viewpoints that take into account the whole person (mind, body, spirit) and the connection to people, lands and living things.
Inuit, Inuk	Inuit are Indigenous Peoples in Northern Canada, living mainly in Nunavut, Northwest Territories, northern Québec, and Labrador. The translation of Inuit is 'the people' in the Inuktitut language and therefore it is redundant to add "people" after it. *Inuk* is used when referring to one Inuit. *Inuuk* is used when referring to two Inuit. Do not use 'Eskimo' which the Inuit consider to be a derogatory term.
knowledge keeper/ Knowledge Keeper/ Knowledge Holder	capitalize when preceding a name; lower-case when standing alone

land title/ land claim	use “land title” instead of “land claim,” which implies that Indigenous Peoples have to apply for ownership rather than having inherent ownership
legends/mythology/ myths/ritual/tales	avoid. They imply Indigenous history and practices are not as legitimate as Western practices. Correct: “oral traditions” or “traditional stories.”
Métis	the term Métis is used to describe a distinct Indigenous group that is unique to Canada and that was originally formed when early explorers formed a kinship with Indigenous communities through marriage. From these unions, a distinct culture was born. Today, children of mixed Indigenous and non-Indigenous ancestry are not automatically ‘Métis’. To be Métis, you must be a descendant of an historic Métis community. The term Métis may be used as a singular or plural and refers to individuals or groups. Be sure to capitalize and use the accent over the ‘e’ in Métis unless quoting a name or source where it is not used. **tip: alt + 0233*
MMIWG	capitalize and spell out when referring to the National Inquiry into Missing and Murdered Indigenous Women and Girls. MMIWG is acceptable in headlines (The Canadian Press).
native	To be ‘native’ to a place means to be from there. However, this term was used to describe Indigenous Peoples in derogatory ways in the past and has therefore fallen out of use. Some Indigenous people or Indigenous organizations may still use this term to describe themselves, *for example: ‘I work at the Native Friendship Centre’*. While those Indigenous people that still self-identify as Native and use this term can do so, it does not mean that non-Indigenous people can use that term to describe Indigenous people today.
on-reserve, off-reserve	don’t use these terms unless they’re the preference of the individual
Oral Histories/ Traditions	when referring to the stories, histories, and cultural knowledge passed down through generations within Indigenous communities, it is appropriate to capitalize the term ‘Oral Traditions’

People, Peoples

Indigenous people can refer to Indigenous individuals or to Indigenous groups, communities or populations. When referring t multiple Indigenous Nations, sometimes it is preferable to use Indigenous Peoples as this recognizes the many distinct Indigenous Nations and Peoples.

Using possessives: Indigenous people do not belong to Canada. Do not use terms such as 'Canada's First Nations people' or 'our Indigenous people'. It is insulting and invokes a history of control by the Settler state of Canada.

- use *Indigenous/Aboriginal people*' instead of '*Aboriginals'*
- use '*the Indigenous Peoples of what is now known as Canada'* instead of '*Indigenous Peoples of Canada'*

The use of the plural form "Indigenous peoples" is important in acknowledging the diversity of distinct groups within Canada's Indigenous population.

In some instances, using the singular "Indigenous people" might appear to generalize the various communities or reduce them to a mere collection of individuals. In contrast, "Indigenous Peoples" (plural) emphasizes the existence of multiple, separate Indigenous populations.

The term "Peoples" emphasizes the collective nature of Indigenous rights, including the right to self-determination. This is crucial because self-determination is a collective right that allows Indigenous peoples to decide their own political status, economic, social, and cultural development. This recognition is essential for respecting and protecting unique identities and ways of life.

Indigenous negotiators advocated strongly for the United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples the use of the term "Peoples" instead of "people" because it recognizes the collective rights and distinct identities of various Indigenous groups.

- Indigenous Peoples – the United Nations describes Indigenous Peoples as those who inhabited a country or geographical region at the time when people of different cultures or ethnic origins arrived.
- an Indigenous People – a specific group of Indigenous Peoples. Example: The Métis are an Indigenous People.
- Indigenous people – individuals of Indigenous descent; synonymous with "persons"

powwow	A powwow (or pow wow, Powwow, or Pow Wow) is a vibrant celebration of dance, drums, and songs. Each spelling is valid, and it's often best to follow the preference of the group or community hosting the event. These gatherings are rich with tradition, serving as festivals, competitions, reunions, arts and crafts showcases, and food fairs —it's an experience that engages all five senses in unforgettable ways.
poles and posts	'Totem pole' is a general term, not all Nations have them. There are different types of poles, statutory figures and posts. Other names for Totem poles can be translated as Clan or House totems. These identify the Clan or Wilp (Gitxsan for House group) that protects and uses the land in that totem's territory. Traditionally this allowed others to identify the People whose territory they were moving through. It also identified who to ask for permission to use the land for themselves for a time. For example, when they need to hunt/harvest to get a stock of food to keep travelling. Speak with the Nation, Elder, Knowledge Keeper or other knowledgeable individual from the Nation about what kind of pole or post is being discussed and its purpose and history.
regalia	traditional Indigenous dress; don't use costume or outfit
reserve/territory	a "reserve" in Alberta is a specific area of land set aside by the federal government for the use of a particular First Nation. These reserves were historically where First Nation members were required to live. When referring to these areas, it is generally more respectful to use the term "community" instead of "reserve," unless the context requires geographic or legal precision. Use "traditional territory" in recognition of lands traditionally used and/or occupied by First Nations, and "ancestral" for lands handed down to subsequent generations, but only if you know this to be the case. "Unceded" refers to land not turned over to the Crown by treaty or some other agreement.
residential schools	use Indian Residential School System in first reference
stakeholders	'Stakeholder' is a common corporate term for partners which has negative connotations to many Indigenous Peoples. Use partners or community members instead. When land acquisition was happening, this term referred to the allotment of land to settlers. Settlers were given wooden stakes to claim their plot of land prior to any treaty or land negotiations with Indigenous Peoples. It's more appropriate to refer to Indigenous Peoples as partners rather than stakeholders. Indigenous Peoples are not stakeholders; they're Aboriginal rights holders whose rights are protected under the Constitution of Canada.

Status Indian	people who have certain rights under the federal Indian Act (see Indian Act above). Rarely necessary to use it but if you do, clarify that it means "Status Indian under the Indian Act."
Sun Dance	capitalize
treaty/Treaty	capitalize "Treaty" when referring to specific treaties, e.g., Treaty 6. Lowercase in general usage.
tribe, tribal	use caution. Still used in some cases (e.g., Blood Tribe, tribal police and in the United States) but in general not appropriate. (Indigenous Elements of Style)
Two Spirit, Two-Spirit	a term specific to Indigenous gender and sexually diverse individuals. Common abbreviation is 2S. Some individuals prefer two spirited. Note: Not all identify as Two Spirit; always ask a person's preference.
United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples	When shortening the name of the United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples, it's the preference to use the term UN Declaration, and **not** the acronym UNDRIP.
unmarked graves	use "confirmed" rather than terms such as "discovered" in reference to residential schools in Canada; Indigenous communities have known of the graves' existence for a long time. Note: they are not mass graves, as is sometimes erroneously reported. (See Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Canada)